

things around the world. When these systems break down because the sea lines of communication are severed or threatened, naval action is required. Uninhibited movement of the vast majority of the traded goods around the globe relies, in the last resort, on the famous phrase of the 19th-century American naval officer, and historian, Alfred Mahan: "command of the sea." The world today is fortunate that trading nations are able to move materials almost anywhere without interference, something we all take for granted.

What naval history tells us, however, is that this freedom, like most others, is not cost-free, and that, periodically, a price has to be paid. The classic way of ensuring command of the sea is to find the battle fleet of the enemy, and destroy it. This has the added benefit for maritime nations of reducing or preventing any chance of invasion. The incidents resulting from the attempts to deny or maintain command of the sea are the battles recorded in this book.

These battles, usually short in duration, tell just a part of what sea power is all about. A key part of historical experience is the ability of maritime powers to project their land power over huge distances, often to a place of their choosing rather than that of their antagonist, to impose a seemingly endless blockade upon an enemy, and to deal with piracy and illegal commerce. They also have the power to do good around the world: working for the abolition of the slave trade, providing assistance to disaster-hit lands, or simply "showing the flag" to reassure friends and deter enemies.

Naval warfare is the story of the use of the most modern, high-tech, and sometimes expensive equipment that a nation can procure. A technological advantage could sometimes define the difference between victory at sea and defeat. The study of naval battles, however, confirms that they are really about people, not just the senior commanders, famous, or notorious, as they might be, but the ordinary man doing extraordinary things under the most stressful of circumstances out of loyalty to his shipmates, his ship, and his country. He is the true hero of this book.

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